

Biblioteca

User Guide

Program version: 1.9.21

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Introduction

What the program does

Biblioteca is the catalogue of your personal library. For each book it keeps the title, the authors, the subjects, the year, the country it comes from, where the copy is in your home, whether it is on loan, the cover photo and your own notes.

From that you can search any of those fields, filter, print a book's record, export the selection to Excel, and see on a map where what you read comes from.

This is the Mac version. It is an ordinary application, with its own icon and window — it is not a website. The internet is only used when you ask for it: looking a book up by ISBN, or fetching a cover.

The same catalogue is read by the Windows, iPhone and Android apps, because all four write to the same file.

What it needs

A text file called biblioteca.txt, which is your library. Each line is a book, with the fields separated by tabs — the TSV format.

If you keep that file in a Biblioteca folder inside iCloud Drive, the app finds it by itself the first time it opens. If not, it asks.

And if you do not have that file yet, you do not need to create it elsewhere: the first-run window creates one for you. The chapter "The first time you open it" shows how.

Beside it, optionally, a biblioteca.dat with the cover photos and a grupos.json with the names of your reading groups. All three live in the same folder, and the app looks after all of them.

What it produces

biblioteca.txt itself, rewritten on every change — there is no save button, and nothing is left pending.

On demand: a book's record for printing, a search report with the filters you used written at the top, an .xlsx spreadsheet with the selected books, and the biblioteca.dat with the covers.

And, without your asking, backups in a Backups folder beside your file: 30 generations of the .txt and 7 of the .dat.

Installing

Biblioteca for the Mac comes in a .dmg file of about 2 MB. It needs nothing installed beforehand and works on macOS 13 Ventura or newer.

The app is recognised by Apple, so it opens straight away, with no security warning.

macOS 13 Ventura or newer

Installing is the usual Mac routine: open the .dmg and drag the app into the Applications folder.

1. Download Biblioteca-Mac.dmg from https://ruggierow.github.io/biblioteca/ and double-click it.
2. Drag "Biblioteca Web" into the Applications folder, as usual.
3. If you already had the previous version, confirm the replacement. Your biblioteca.txt and biblioteca.dat are not touched.
4. Eject the installer disk and open the app from Launchpad or from the Applications folder.

Checking that it worked

The app opens in a window with a blue-and-green gradient header, the name "Personal Library Manager" and the version beside it. If your library already existed, the list shows up filled in at the bottom of the page, with the count to the right of the "Book list" heading. If this is the first time, the list is empty and "The biblioteca.txt file" band already shows the folder the app picked on its own — the chapter "The first time" explains how to change it.

The window and the language

Everything happens on a single page, which you go through from top to bottom: first adding a book, then search, editing, the indexes, the map, the file and, last, the book list. The header stays visible at the top, with the language selector and the quit button.

Step by step

1. To change the language, click the selector in the top right corner and choose Português or English.
2. The change takes effect at once, without restarting the app, and is remembered for the next time you open it.
3. To close, use the "Quit" button in the header — it writes anything pending before leaving.



Figure 1: The header, with the language selector and the Quit button

Examples

- The first time you open the app, the language follows the Mac's: on a Mac in Portuguese it opens in Portuguese; in any other language, it opens in English.
- Once you pick a language in the selector, your choice always wins — even if the Mac is set to another language.

The first time: choosing the folder

Your books live in a text file called `biblioteca.txt`. You do not have to create it anywhere: just tell the app which folder it is in — or which folder you want it to live in. That is what the "Choose folder" button does, and it is the same one on all four platforms.

It is the first button in "The biblioteca.txt file" band. And if you never choose anything, the app does not sit still: it uses the Biblioteca folder in your iCloud Drive, the same one the iPhone looks for.

Step by step

1. Scroll to "The biblioteca.txt file" band and click "Choose folder".
2. The Mac's folder window opens already at the folder the app is using. Pick the folder where your biblioteca.txt is — or where you want it to live from now on — and click "Select".
3. The app looks at the folder and tells you what it found. There are four possible answers, and in all of them you end up ready to add books.

What the app answers

The folder already had a library

It says how many books it found and asks whether that is the one. The count is there on purpose: accepting a file without knowing what is inside it would be a guess.

The folder was empty

It creates biblioteca.txt there and tells you. It asks nothing — you have just picked that folder for exactly this.

There is a file and it could not be read

It says what happened and offers another folder. It never writes over it: that may be somebody's library, or a file still coming down from the cloud.

You changed folders with books already open

If the new folder is empty, it asks what to do with the books in view: move them there, or start a new, empty library. Either way, the library in the old folder is left untouched.

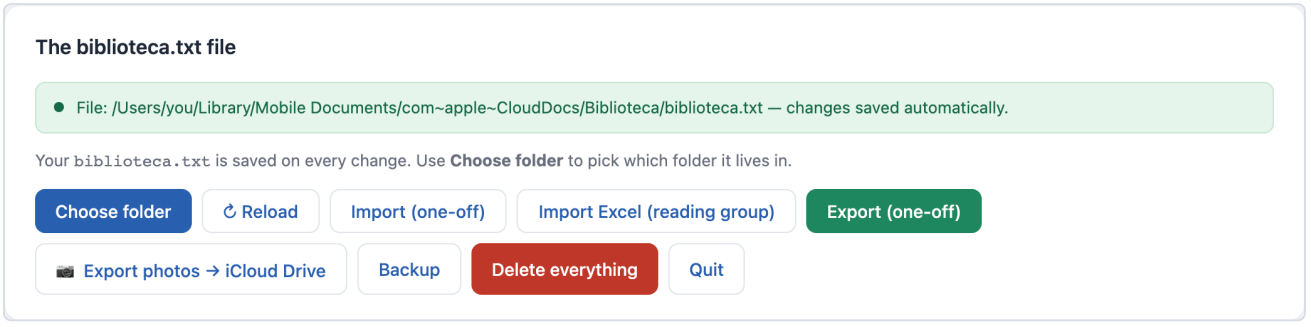


Figure 2: The file band, with "Choose folder" first

Examples

- Where to keep it: if you use the app on more than one device, pick the Biblioteca folder inside iCloud Drive. That is what makes the Mac and the iPhone see the same collection.

- Somewhere else works too: an external disk, a Dropbox folder. If that folder is unreachable when the app opens, it falls back to the iCloud one on its own — and the path in the band shows it. It does not write to a dead path.
- Changing folders later is the same button. It is not only for the first time.
- What about biblioteca.dat, the one with the covers? It is not born with it. It only comes into being once you have covers and publish them. Until then nothing is missing: the app works without it.

Adding a book

It is the first block on the page. It adds a book to the catalogue, and the least you need is the title.

Step by step

1. If you have the ISBN at hand, type it in the first field and click "Look up ISBN": the title, the authors and the year come filled in from the internet.
2. Fill in or correct the Title. It is the only required field.
3. Click "+ Add author" once for each author, and "+ Add subject" once for each subject.
4. Fill in the Year, Where the copy is (where the book sits in your home) and, if you like, the Country.
5. Use Notes for whatever is yours: a summary, a memory, who gave you the book.
6. If the book was discussed in a reading group, tick the box and choose the groups.
7. Under "Cover photo", click "Choose photo..." to pick an image from the computer.
8. Click "Add book". The book shows up in the list and the file is written at once.

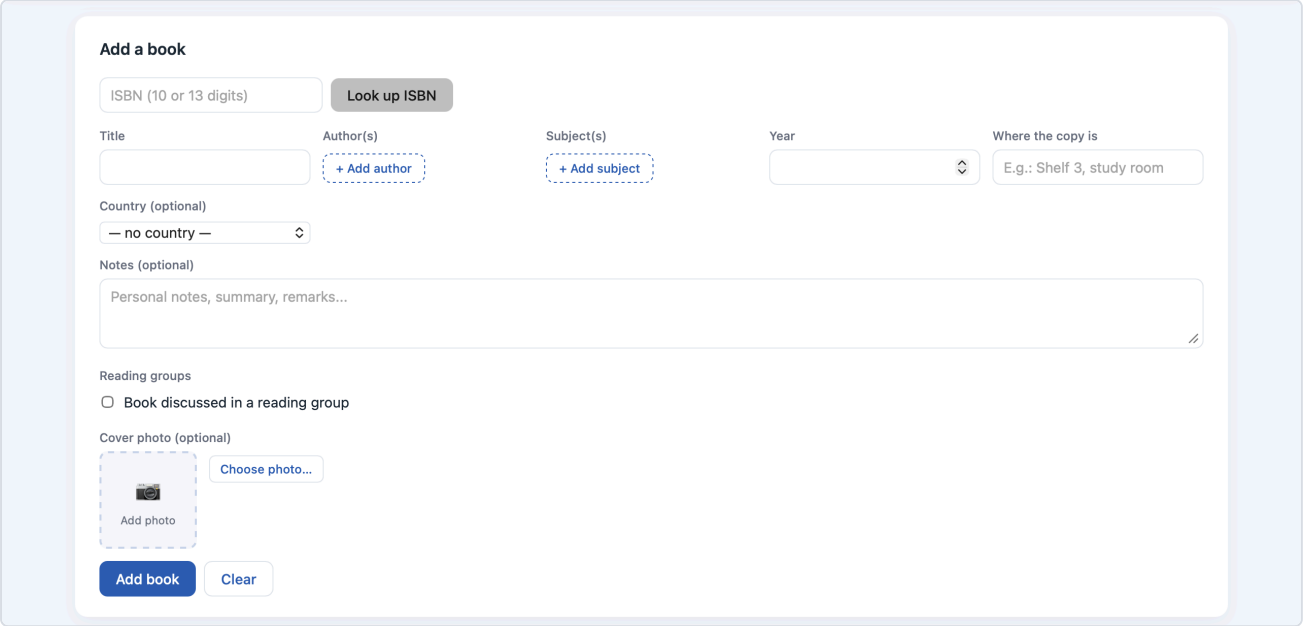


Figure 3: The add-a-book form, with every field of a book

Examples

- Quick entry: type only the title and click Add book. The other fields can be filled in later, by editing.
- Entry by ISBN: type 9788535902778 and click Look up ISBN. Check what came back — the lookup almost always gets the title right, but it sometimes gives the author's name in a different order from yours.
- The "Clear" button empties the form without adding anything, handy when you give up halfway.

Searching and filtering

The "Search and filter" block looks for parts of words in four fields at once, and also filters by status, reading group and whether there is a photo. The filters add up: the more you fill in, the narrower the result.

Step by step

1. Type a piece of what you are looking for in Title, Author, Subject or Location — it need not be the whole word, and case does not matter.
2. Under Status, choose between all, available or on loan.
3. Under Reading group, choose a group to see only the books discussed in it.

4. Tick "With photo" to see only the books that already have a cover.
5. Click "Search". The list at the bottom of the page now shows only the result.
6. "Clear filters" gives the whole list back.

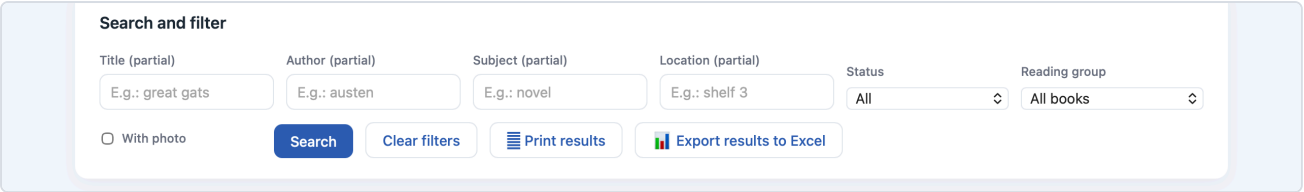


Figure 4: The search fields and the print and export buttons

Examples

- Search by author: type "machado" in Author and click Search — every book by Machado de Assis comes back, even if you entered the full name.
- Find a book on the shelf: type "shelf 3" in Location to see everything kept there.
- Two filters together: "novel" in Subject plus Status "On loan" shows which novels are out of the house.
- With the result on screen, "Print results" makes a report with the filters you used written at the top, and "Export results to Excel" saves the same selection as a spreadsheet.

Editing a book

This is for correcting an entry. The "Edit book" block has a list of every book and a field to narrow it as you type; the form opens in a window on top of the page.

Step by step

1. Type part of the title, the author or the subject in "Filter the list by title, author or subject".
2. Pick the book in the "Book to edit" list.
3. Click "Edit selected". The window opens with the current details filled in.
4. Change what you need and click "Save". "Cancel" closes without writing anything.
5. The same window opens from the "Edit" button on the book's row, in the table at the bottom of the page — usually quicker when you are already looking at the list.

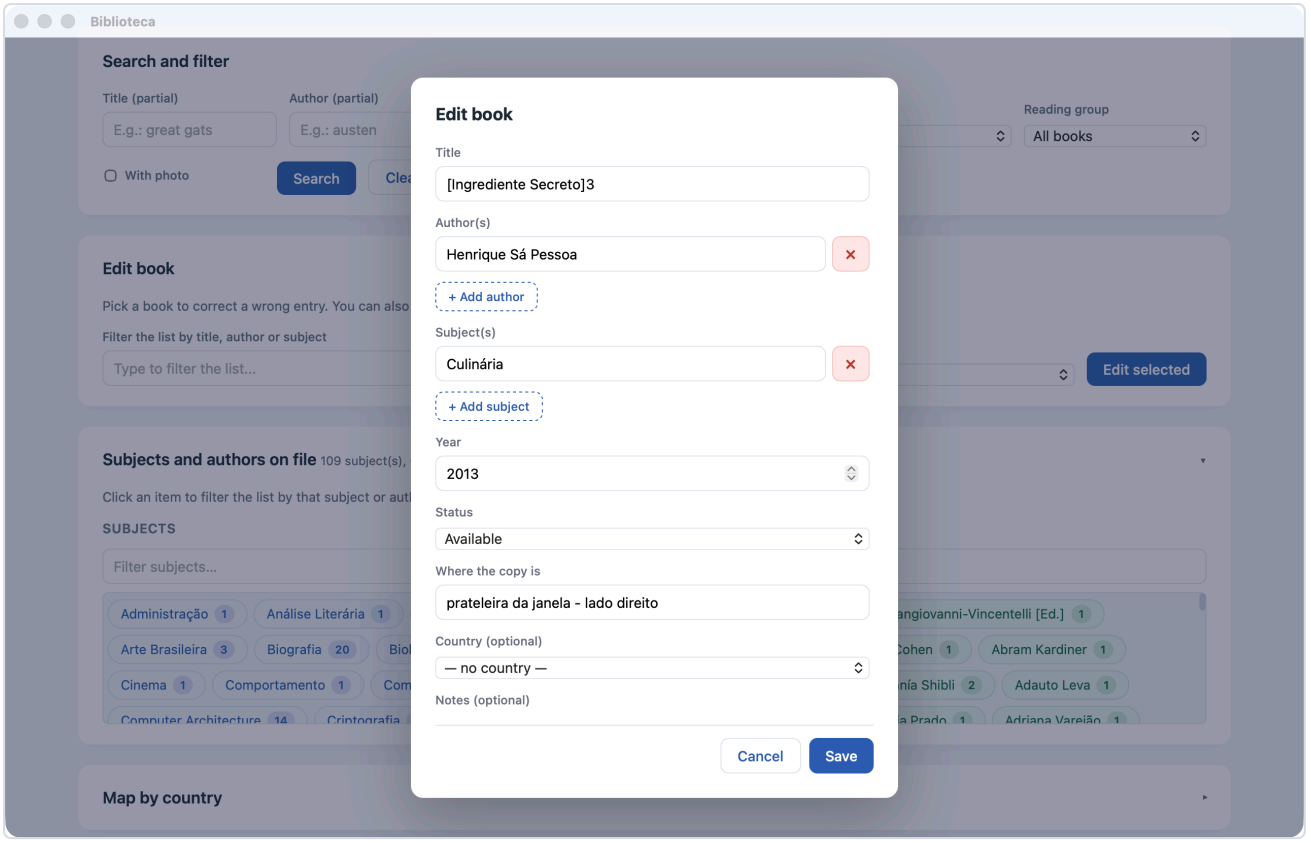


Figure 5: The edit window, open over the page

Examples

- Fix a wrong year: filter by the title, select it, edit the Year field and save.
- Add a cover to an old book: edit it and use "Choose photo..."; the cover then shows in the first column of the list.

Subjects and authors on file

Two indexes side by side, with the number of books for each subject and each author. They are both a way to see your collection from above and a one-click filter.

Step by step

1. Click the "Subjects and authors on file" heading to open or close the block.
2. Use "Filter subjects..." or "Filter authors..." to find an item in a long list.
3. Click a subject or an author: the list at the bottom of the page then shows only that item's books.

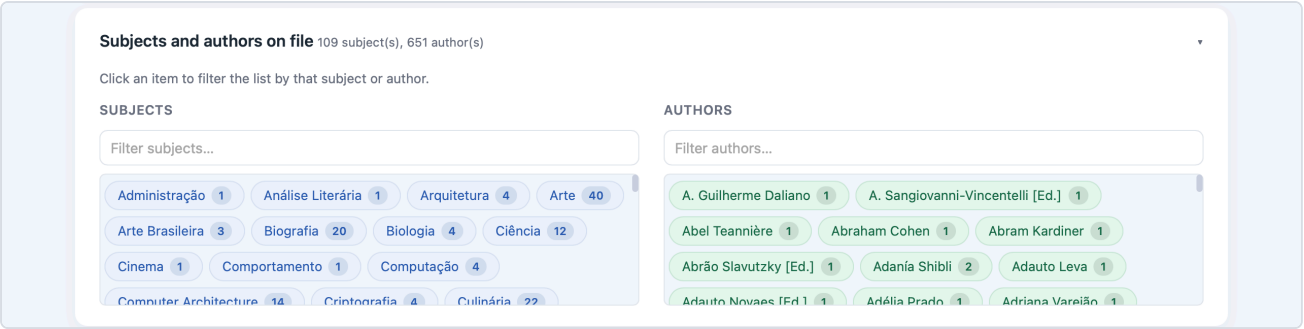


Figure 6: The subject and author indexes, each with its count

Examples

- The number beside the name is how many books you have of that subject or author — "Arte 40" means forty books on Art.
- It is the quickest way to answer "how many books do I have by this author?" without typing anything.

The map by country

Each bubble is a country, in its place on the world, and its size is how many books you have from there. Below it, the same counts as an ordered list.

A book's country is where the literature comes from, not where the edition was printed: a Brazilian edition of Tolstoy counts as Russia.

Step by step

1. Click the "Map by country" heading to open the block.
2. Click a bubble to filter the book list by that country.
3. The line under the map says how many books already have a country and how many do not yet.

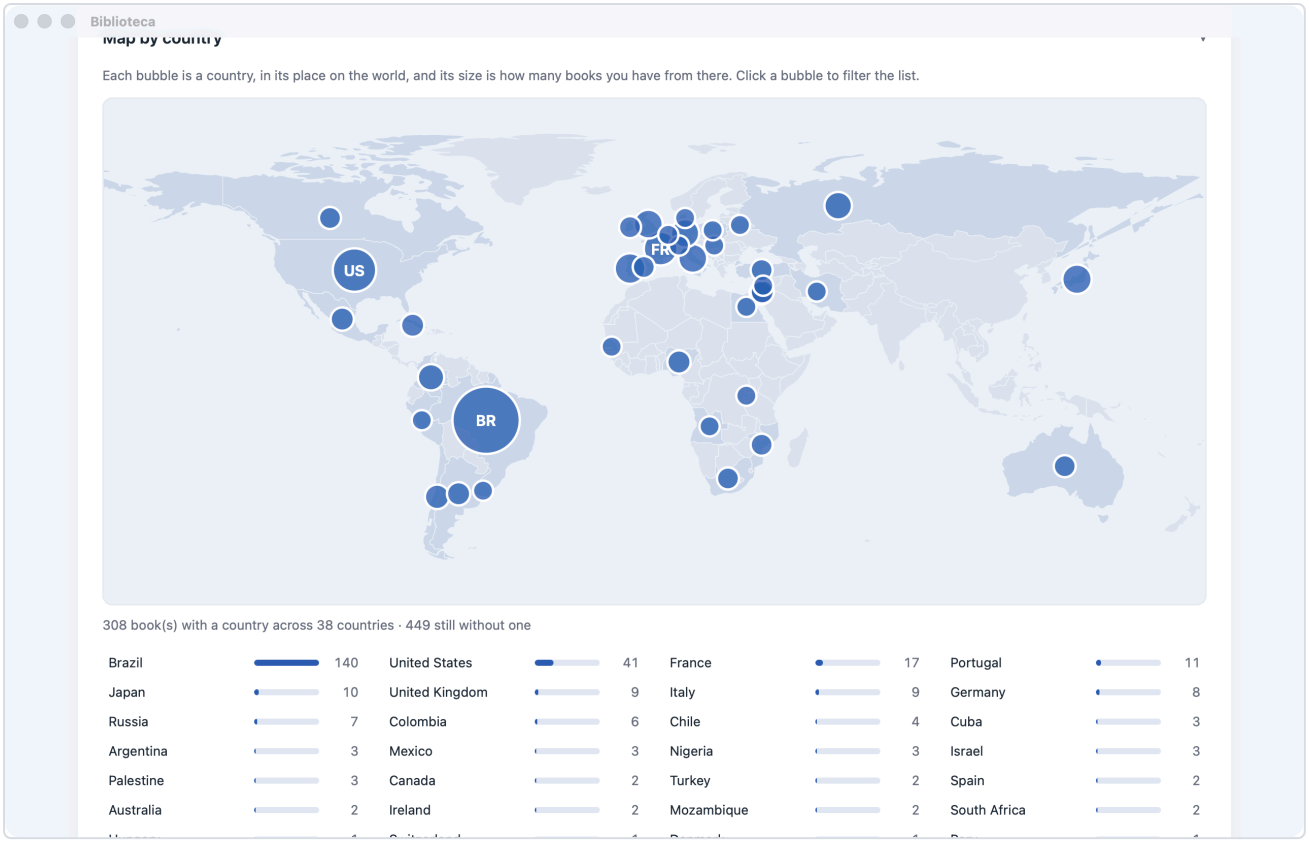


Figure 7: The map, one bubble per country, with the counts below

Examples

- The country is optional, and the map does not expect every book to have one — it shows the count for those that do and says how many are still missing.
- To give a book a country, edit it and pick one in the Country field.

The biblioteca.txt file

The "The biblioteca.txt file" band is where the app says which file it is working with and offers everything to do with it: reload, import, export and back up. It is also where the delete-everything button lives.

Step by step

1. The status line, at the top of the band, shows the file's full path and says that changes are saved automatically.
2. "Reload" reads the file from disk again — useful if you changed the library on another device and want that change here.

3. "Import (one-off)" reads a biblioteca.txt from somewhere else; "Import Excel (reading group)" reads a group spreadsheet.
4. "Export (one-off)" writes a copy of the catalogue wherever you choose.
5. "Export photos → iCloud Drive" takes the covers to the iCloud folder. It is this button that CREATES biblioteca.dat, the first time you use it.
6. "Backup" writes a dated copy into the Backups folder.

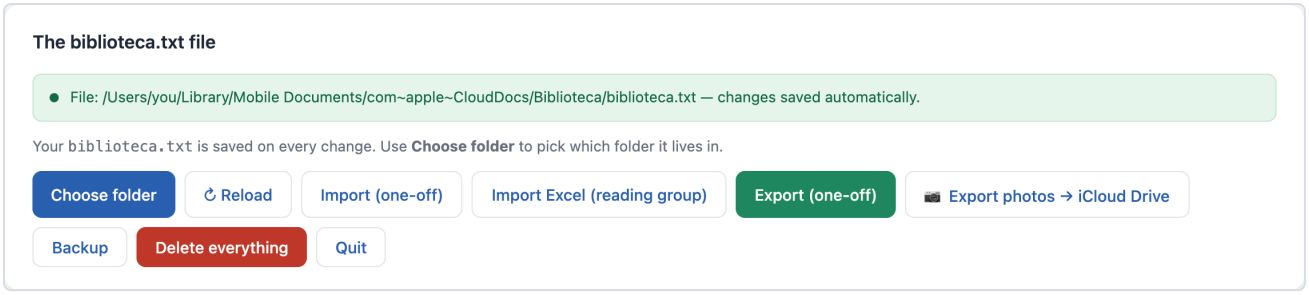


Figure 8: The file band, with import, export and backup

Examples

- There is no save button: every change is written to the file the moment you make it.
- Before the first write of each session, the app keeps a copy of the previous state in Backups by itself — 30 generations of the .txt and 7 of the .dat.
- biblioteca.dat is the file where the Mac and the iPhone keep every cover, side by side with the .txt. Android READS it but does not write it: covers are published by this app and by the iPhone one.
- "Delete everything" is destructive and asks for confirmation. It empties the catalogue, not just the screen.

The book list

The last block on the page is the table of books, ten to a page. It shows the cover, the title, the authors, the subjects, the year, the status, the location, the note and the groups — and carries, on every row, that book's action buttons.

Step by step

1. The count to the right of the heading says how many books are being shown out of the total — "757 of 757 book(s)" means no filter is active.
2. Use the pagination at the bottom of the table to move between pages.

3. "Edit" opens the book in the edit window.
4. "Lend" marks the book as on loan and asks who to.
5. "Print" produces that book's record.
6. "Remove" deletes the book, with confirmation.

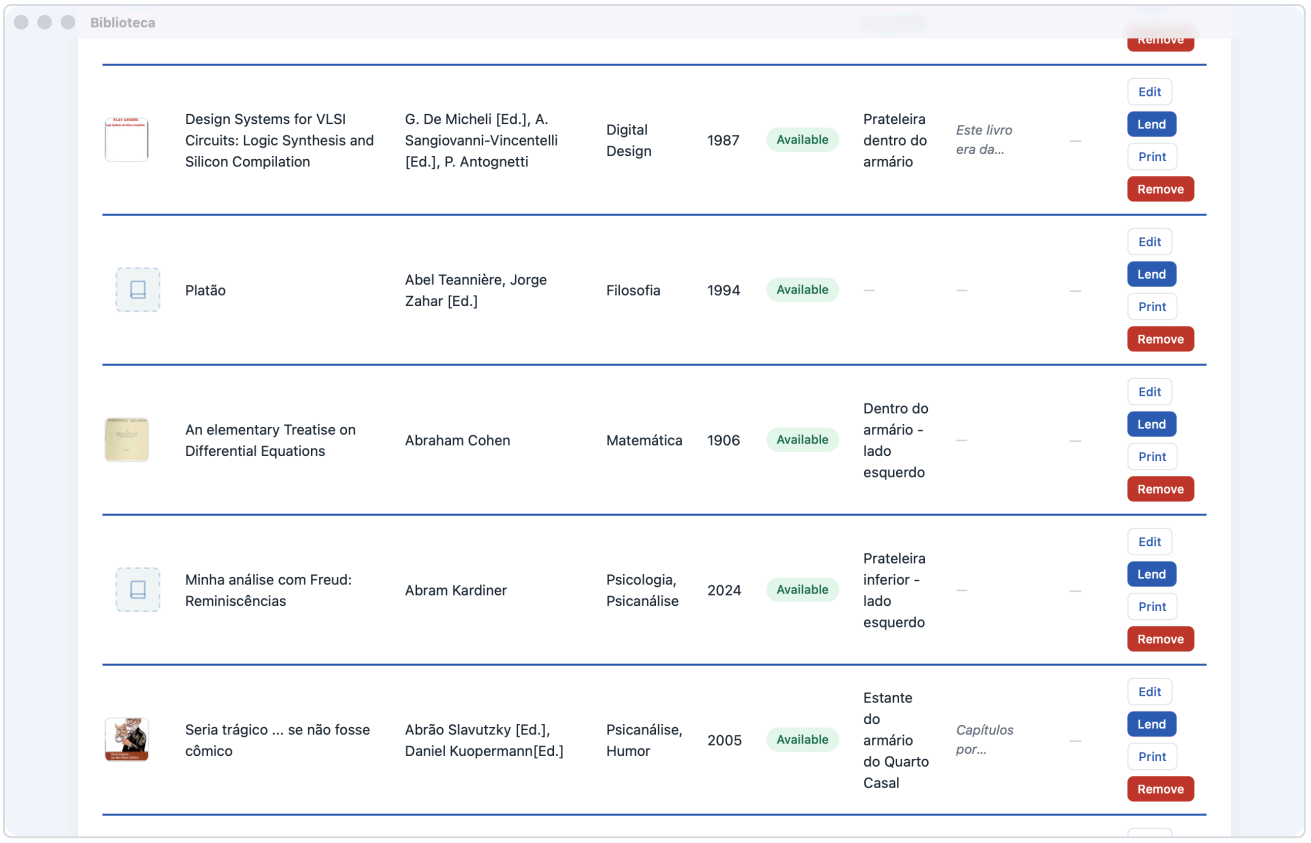


Figure 9: The book table, with the covers and each row's buttons

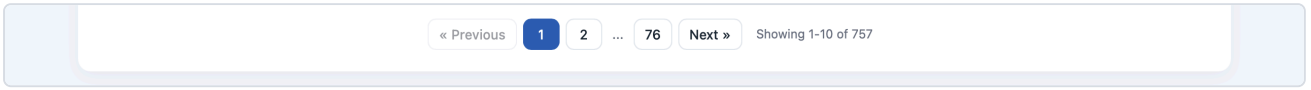


Figure 10: The pagination and the count, at the end of the table

Examples

- When a book has a web address in its note, the column shows "Ler" and "Kindle" links, which open the book in the browser or in the Kindle app.
- The GROUP column shows the name of the reading group where the book was discussed, not just a "yes".
- Books with no cover show a grey book icon in place of the photo.

Tutorial: from the .dmg to your first book with a cover

This is the whole path for someone who has never used the app and does not have a biblioteca.txt yet. At the end of it you come out with the file created, a book in it and the cover in place.

1. Download Biblioteca-Mac.dmg, open it and drag "Biblioteca Web" into Applications.
2. Open the app and scroll to "The biblioteca.txt file" band.
3. Click "Choose folder". In the Mac's folder window, go to iCloud Drive, create a folder called Biblioteca there and select it. Since it is empty, the app creates biblioteca.txt and tells you. The file now exists.
4. In the "Add a book" block, type the ISBN from the back cover of a book you have at hand and click "Look up ISBN".
5. Check the title and authors that came back, add a subject and write in Where the copy is where the book sits — "Shelf 3", for instance.
6. Under "Cover photo", click "Choose photo..." and pick a picture of the cover.
7. Click "Add book". Scroll to the bottom of the page: the book is in the table, with its cover in the first column.
8. Go back to the "The biblioteca.txt file" band and click "Export photos → iCloud Drive". This is what creates biblioteca.dat, beside your .txt. From here on the iPhone can see the cover too.

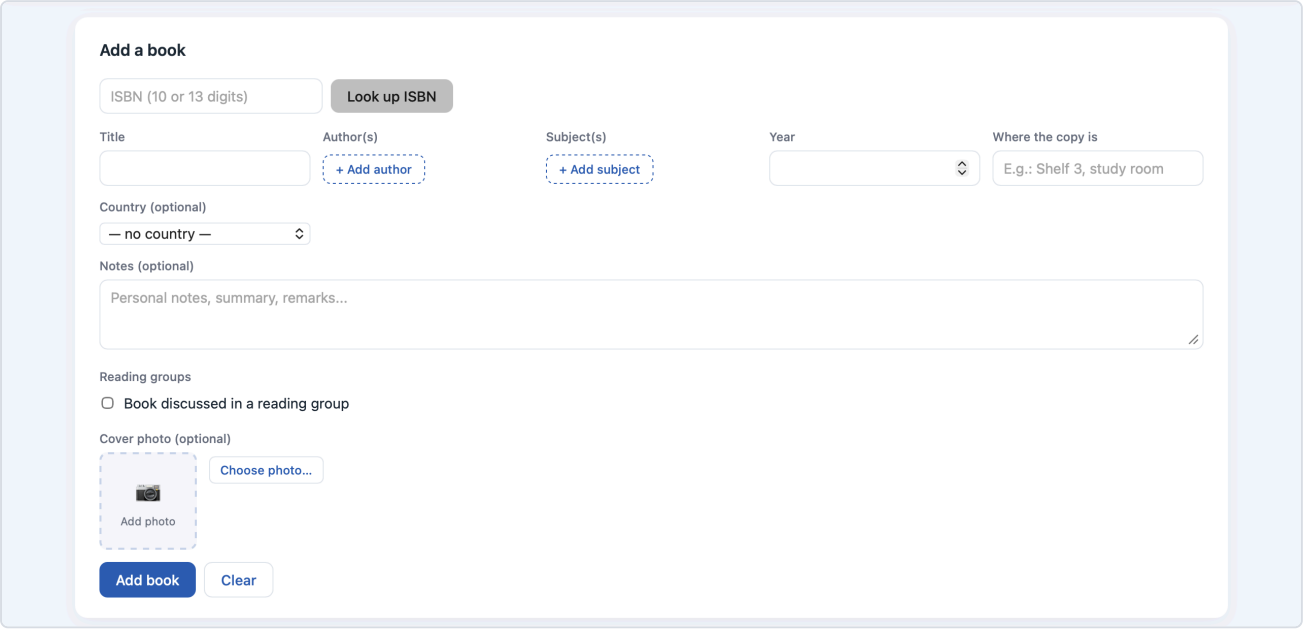


Figure 11: The form filled in, just before adding the book

Troubleshooting

I opened the app for the first time and I do not know how to create my biblioteca.txt.

You do not need to create it elsewhere. In "The biblioteca.txt file" band, click "Choose folder" and pick the folder where it should live: if that folder is empty, the app creates the file there and tells you.

I do not have a biblioteca.dat. What am I missing?

Nothing. It only comes into existence once you have covers and use "Export photos → iCloud Drive". Without it the app works just the same; what does not happen is the iPhone and Android seeing your covers.

The app opened empty, but my library does exist.

It did not find the file in the folder it is using. Go to "The biblioteca.txt file" band, click "Choose folder" and point at the folder where it is — the app says how many books it found before switching. Do not add anything before doing that.

The app opens in English and my Mac is in Portuguese.

On first run the app follows the system language, and what it reads is the first language in Language & Region — which can be English even on a Mac used in Portuguese. Pick Português in the header selector: your choice wins from then on.

I changed the library on the iPhone and the Mac does not show it.

Click "Reload" in the file band. The app reads the file when it opens, not continuously — and iCloud also takes a few seconds to bring the new version across.

The ISBN lookup did not find the book.

That happens with old editions and small print runs, which are not in the databases consulted. Type the title by hand: nothing else depends on the ISBN.

I deleted a book by mistake.

There is a Backups folder beside your file, with 30 generations. Take the most recent one from before the mistake and use "Import (one-off)".

I used to see a welcome window on the first run, and it is gone.

It was removed in this version. The option it recommended relied on a file picker the Mac app does not have — whoever chose it saw nothing happen. That job now belongs to the "Choose folder" button, in "The biblioteca.txt file" band.

Glossary

biblioteca.txt

The file where the catalogue lives. Plain text, one book per line, fields separated by tabs. It is the same file on all four platforms.

biblioteca.dat

The file of cover photos, beside the .txt. It is not born with it: it is created the first time you use "Export photos → iCloud Drive".

TSV

Tab-separated values. It is the format of biblioteca.txt, and it is what lets you open it in any editor or spreadsheet without depending on this app.

ISBN

The 10- or 13-digit number that identifies an edition. It is what the barcode on the back cover carries.

Where the copy is

Where your book physically is — the shelf, the box, the house of whoever borrowed it. Search looks in this field too.

Reading group

A mark for books discussed in a group, with the group's name. It works as a filter in search.

Choose folder

Telling the app which folder your biblioteca.txt is in — or which folder you want it to live in. Done once, the app remembers, and writes there on every change. It is the same button on all four platforms.

References

- The app's page: https://ruggierow.github.io/biblioteca/
- Manuals for the other platforms (Windows, iPhone and Android) on the same page.

- The biblioteca.txt format is described in comum/formato-tsv.md, in the project repository.